Lament

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‘Lament’

Here is a detailed guide to Gillian Clarke’s poem ‘Lament’, from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview**: a line-by-line “translation” of the poem’s meanings and interpretations
- **Writer’s methods**: an exploration of Clarke’s poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text**: an exploration of the themes and ideas within Clarke’s poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A “translation” of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Gillian Clarke’s intention and message

‘Lament’ overview

The poem ‘Lament’, by Gillian Clarke, is a simple expression of grief about the circumstances of the modern world and conflict in particular. Each stanza focuses on a different consequence to show the far-reaching and damaging effects of war.

‘Lament’ breakdown

Lines 1-3

> **“For the green turtle with her pulsing burden,**
> **in search of the breeding ground.**
> **For her eggs laid in their nest of sickness.”**

Translation

for a safe place to lay her eggs

- The speaker says the nest is in a place of "sickness", perhaps implying the beach is polluted and diseased

Clarke's intentions

- Clarke's poem is presented as an elegy
- It begins with an expression of sorrow for animals like the "green turtle" who struggles to adapt to changing environmental conditions
- Immediately, Clarke introduces ideas about the natural world, and that it may be sick, metaphorically and literally

Lines 4-6

> **"For the cormorant in his funeral silk,**
> **the veil of iridescence on the sand,**
> **the shadow on the sea."**

Translation

- The speaker grieves for birds, such as the cormorant
- The bird's feathers are described as black ("funeral") silk
- The speaker adds that the sand and sea are darkened by a "veil" and a "shadow":
  - But there is also "iridescence", which describes bright colours reflected in oil

Clarke's intentions

- Gillian Clarke connotes to death with imagery that implies the cormorant wears "funeral" feathers, and is close to dying in a natural world polluted by humans
- Clarke uses contrasts to show the sinister consequences of oil-spills:
  - The sand and sea are in "shadow" of darkness, but there is an unnatural "iridescence" in the brightly-coloured oil

Lines 7-9

> **"For the ocean's lap with its mortal stain.**
> **For Ahmed at the closed border.**
> **For the soldier with his uniform of fire."**

Translation

- The poem continues its list of tributes, now describing coasts and borders
- The ocean leaves a "mortal stain" on the shoreline, which alludes to people who have died as a result of warfare, or at sea, and connotes to a "stain" of blood on the sand

Clarke's intentions

- Clarke's poem considers the impact of war on nature and humans
- The reference to "Ahmed" indicates a specific area of the world, alluding to twentieth century Middle Eastern conflicts, specifically the Gulf War

Lines 10-12

> **"For the gunsmith and the armourer,**
> **the boy fusilier who joined for the company,**
> **the farmer's sons, in it for the music."**

Translation

- The speaker lists a range of people who, perhaps unwittingly, contribute to war
- The list includes:
  - The people who make the weapons ("armourer" and "gunsmith")
  - The soldier who joined the army to make friends
  - The sons of farmers who are only doing it for sense of camaraderie ("music")

Clarke's intentions

- Clarke intends to show how war is successful because of the many people who support it, even when they do not even realise its effects
- Describing a "fusilier" as a boy, and referring to "farmer's sons" implies that they are naïve
- The reference to joining for the "company" and "music" alludes to war propaganda that encourages young boys to join the military to feel a sense of belonging

Lines 13-15

> **"For the hook-beaked turtles,**
> **the dugong and the dolphin,**
> **the whale struck dumb by the missile's thunder."**

Translation

- A list of sea animals are included in the lament
- They have been silenced by a the noise ("thunder") of a missile

Clarke's intentions

- The juxtaposition of ideas about the natural world placed next to references to war creates a sinister effect, and presents Clarke's ideas about how war damages nature:

accentuates the far reaching effects of war

Lines 16-18

> **"For the tern, the gull and the restless wader,**
> **the long migrations and the slow dying,**
> **the veiled sun and the stink of anger."**

Translation

- The speaker pays tribute to a range of sea birds (the "tern", "gull" and "wader")
- The speaker says that the birds are slowly dying because they have to fly further and further to migrate
- The speaker describes again the covering of the sun, as well as a metaphorical smell of "anger", which may represent the speaker's feelings, or the way nature feels

Clarke's intentions

- The list of sea birds struggling to adapt to environmental change emphasises the extent of the damage done to the natural order of things
- Again, Clarke refers to darkness and connotes to a funeral in a "veiled" sun:
    - Dark imagery, such as a smell of "anger", creates an ominous tone

Lines 19-21

> **"For the burnt earth and the sun put out,**
> **the scalded ocean and the blazing well.**
> **For vengeance, and the ashes of language."**

Translation

- The poem ends with descriptions of a world ravaged by war and bombs: the earth has been "burnt", the ocean "scalded", and wells of water are "blazing"
- Again, the speaker describes the sun becoming dark, but now it is entirely "put out"
- The final line suggests revenge is now the overriding concept for humanity, and that "language" has been burned into "ashes", connoting to the end of civilisation and communication

Clarke's intentions

- Clarke's poem ends with a description of a dark landscape that has been scorched
- The "earth", the "sun", the "ocean", and "language" have been destroyed
- The ending is not so much a warning as an extended metaphor of a funeral, during which the speaker grieves a

Examiner Tips and Tricks

In the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme rewards skills of analysis, which they describe as "the ways in which writers achieve their effects". Another way to think of the word "effects" is how a reader is encouraged to respond, or what questions have been raised. Poets create these "effects" through their choice of form, structure, or language.

To explore the poetry question, you could write about how Gillian Clarke, for example, uses the poem's repetitive structure to represent a grieving speaker, or how the poem uses imagery throughout the poem that describes the effects of war.

Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into form, structure, and language, it is worth remembering that all of these are considered "writer's methods" in the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme. With this in mind, consider the poet's choice of form (the way the poem looks or the type of poem it is), its structure (especially how it ends: is it cyclical or resolved?) and, of course, the language used to create effect and, thus, meaning.

By **focusing** on the **poet's overarching ideas** rather than identifying poetic techniques or translating quotes, you will gain far more marks. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Clarke's intentions in terms of her choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

The poem 'Lament' is formed as an elegy: a tribute to something, or someone, that has died. In this way, the speaker provides a sorrowful list of all the things they mourn, which highlights the deadly effects of war on the natural world, as well as on humans.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
The cost of war	The poem's free verse, with pauses at the end of lines, creates a slow and steady rhythm, but the speaker's tone of voice becomes passionate and angrier as the poem's polysyndeton lists increase, such as in "long	Clarke's speaker is a saddened and deeply respectful observer of the damage done to the natural world as a result of war, but there is also a sense of personal anger at

Structure

Gillian Clarke's poem is a reflection on the vast and far-reaching effects of war on the natural world. The poem's speaker gravely and passionately lists all the damaging consequences.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Humans and nature	The poem is divided into 7 tercets, which gives the poem the effect of being a long, slow list	Clarke uses metonymy as she lists the many individual animals, birds, human beings, as well as the natural elements of sea, earth, and sun, that represent the extensive damage caused by war
	The poet uses anaphora in the repetition of "For" to begin stanzas	The poem is formed as a tribute to dying animals and the death of the natural world

Language

'Lament' describes a modern, war-torn world in a sinister extended metaphor that suggests a funeral. The poem implies the death of nature, and of civilisation, as a result of constant conflict.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Humans and nature	Metaphors connote to death: while the turtle lays eggs in a "sick" nest, and the birds have "funeral" feathers, the shorelines of the world are covered in a "mortal stain"	The poet uses the extended metaphor of a funeral to highlight the seriousness of the environmental crisis

	placed alongside the language of war to present sinister connections, such as in "the whale struck dumb by the missile's thunder", but the poem's ending presents, not only a world on fire, but the "ashes" of language	destruction suggests war will kill the natural world, but ambiguously refers to the death of language, which may refer to the idea of cultural identity or, perhaps, the death of what makes us human

Understanding the text

All the questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an informed, personal response, which means that you should develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events**. This will help you to **explore** the **writer's intentions and methods**. This section has been divided into two main themes that Gillian Clarke explores in 'Lament':

- Humans and nature
- The cost of war

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Something that examiners see a lot in poetry responses, and strongly warn against, are essays that begin with long introductions telling us about the poet's life and history. Instead, examiners reward essays that thoroughly explore the circumstances of the poet's ideas. To be rewarded highly for this, you could write about why Gillian Clarke may have wanted to raise questions about war and its impact on the environment in a twentieth century world.

Humans and nature

- Gillian Clarke, born in Wales in 1937, was the National Poet of Wales between 2008 and 2016
- Her poems often explore themes of nature, and the individual's relationship with their environment
- Clarke has said her work is inspired by Romantic poet, William Wordsworth
- In the poem, she mourns the destruction of the natural world, sharing the Romantic concern for nature:
  - The poem begins paying tribute to a struggling "green turtle" who cannot find a safe place to lay her eggs because their usual breeding-grounds are "sick"
  - She refers to birds covered in oil, and "long migrations"

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

- The poem mentions endangered species to highlight how the spill devastated thousands of birds, fish, sea turtles, and marine mammals

The cost of war

- Gillian Clarke's poetry often explores the consequences of poorly-reported news and corrupted media, especially in connection to how it affects the natural world
- The poem 'Lament' alludes, Clarke has said, to the 1990–1991 Gulf War:
  - It mentions a man called "Ahmed" at a "closed border" with an armed soldier
  - It details the burning of earth and "blazing" water wells

- The poem may also alludes to a photograph taken in 1991 by Kenneth Jarecke:
  - In the photograph, not published by American media or press, a man is on fire in the Iraqi desert as armed vehicles drive by
  - Clarke's poem describes young boys and "sons" joining the army to make friends, and ends with a description of the "ashes" of language
  - She alludes to war propaganda and, perhaps, the death of truth

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: what the question is asking and how to get full marks. You will also find an example of a full, annotated model answer.

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

Sources

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